

Superbugs and new viruses

Bacteria and viruses change fast. "Superbug" bacteria become immune to antibiotics, while scientists try to develop vaccines against new viruses. Today, air travel can spread infection worldwide in days, so the fear of a fast-spreading pandemic is greater than ever. Here are five recent cases of new viruses.

- 1 **Hong Kong Flu, 1968–69**
In 2 years, Hong Kong Flu caused about 1 million deaths. The virus killed about 34,000 people in the United States alone.
- 2 **Avian (Bird) Flu, Hong Kong, 1997–present**
This virus first appeared in humans in Hong Kong, through contact with infected poultry. It has killed hundreds of people since then.
- 3 **H1N1 ("Swine Flu"), Mexico City, 2009–10**
This new flu developed from viruses of birds, pigs, and humans. Up to 575,400 people died in the first year of this pandemic.
- 4 **HIV, west-central Africa, 1981–present**
This virus causes AIDS—an often-fatal disease of the body's defenses. It now infects more than 30 million people worldwide.

Black Death

In the 14th century, an outbreak of bubonic plague spread from Asia across Europe, causing devastation along the way. It caused some 50 million deaths—about half in Europe, where 25 percent of the population was killed.

Constantinople (Istanbul)

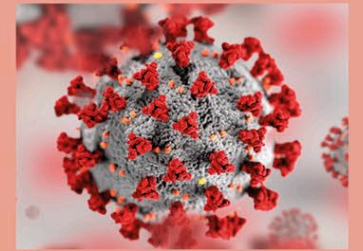
Some experts think the Plague of Justinian began not in Ethiopia, but in Central Asia.

The Black Death passed along sea trade routes, since the bacteria that caused the disease lived in fleas, which lived on ships' rats.

Plague of Justinian

At its height, during the rule of the Emperor Justinian (ruler of the Byzantine, or Eastern Roman, Empire), this disease killed at least 25 million people. It may have started in Ethiopia, then spread along trade routes through northern Egypt and Constantinople (modern-day Istanbul) into Europe.

COVID-19



- 5 **Dec 2019–present**
First identified in Wuhan, China, in late 2019, this fast-spreading virus can cause severe respiratory problems; up to 2.6 million deaths were reported in the first year of the pandemic. Vaccines have now been developed to help protect against the disease.

Spanish Flu was brought to New Zealand in 1918 by soldiers returning home from fighting in World War I in Europe.

**UP TO 2,000 PEOPLE
STILL SUFFER FROM
PLAGUE EACH YEAR**